

A BOOK REVIEW ON THE SCIENCE OF THE SOUL

The 14th-Century Manual That Diagnosed My Modern Anxiety

A Review of Ibn Qayyim's Ad-Dā' wad-Dawā'

ما أنزل الله داء إلا أنزل له شفاء

"Allah has not sent down any disease except that He has also sent down its cure."

— Prophetic tradition, Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī

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I am taking up my pen and my journal, deeply moved once again during my second read of this masterpiece. I first read it two years ago, but recently, I felt my soul desperately needing it again. I went to my bookshelf and pulled it out, and surprisingly, its taste feels completely new to me. I am savoring page after page. It is as if I am sitting right in front of Imam Ibn Qayyim himself, or as if we are sharing a deep, soul-stirring conversation over coffee. I opened my journal to write about this book—a book that feels as though it was meant just for me.

The book is *Ad-Dā' wad-Dawā'* (The Disease and The Cure) by Imam Ibn Qayyim al-Jawziyyah. Written over seven centuries ago, this masterpiece remains one of the most penetrating psychological and spiritual manuals on self-purification, overcoming destructive desires, and the burdens of sin.

I. The Origins of the Book: A Cry for Help

The inception of this monumental work is as moving as its contents. The book was written in response to a desperate question posed to Ibn Qayyim by an anonymous questioner. The questioner described a severe affliction—a sin or destructive habit—that had taken over his life, stating that if it continued, it would destroy him in this world and the next. He pleaded: “What is the cure?” Instead of offering a brief, dismissive fatwa (legal ruling), Ibn Qayyim responded with an entire book, opening his thesis by relying on the famous Prophetic principle¹:

ما أنزل الله داء إلا أنزل له شفاء

“Allah has not sent down any disease except that He has also sent down its cure.”

— Prophetic tradition, cited as the foundation of Ibn Qayyim’s thesis

He treated the questioner not merely as a sinner to be condemned, but as a patient desperately in need of a physician for his soul.

II. The Anatomy of the Disease (Ad-Daa')

As we “spoke,” Ibn Qayyim spent a significant portion of our time diagnosing the “disease.” He defines the ultimate disease as sin and disobedience to the Creator, and more specifically, the heart’s unnatural attachment to things other than Allah.

He meticulously outlines the catastrophic effects that sin has on the human condition. Rather than focusing merely on the legal punishments, Ibn Qayyim focuses on the spiritual and psychological consequences. He famously summarizes this by stating²:

المعاصي للقلب كالسموم للبدن

“Sins are to the heart what poisons are to the body.”

— Ibn Qayyim al-Jawziyyah, *Ad-Dā' wad-Dawā'*

He explains that these spiritual poisons:

- **Blind the Intellect:** They prevent a person from seeing the truth clearly.
- **Darken the Heart:** They create a spiritual veil, leading to depression, anxiety, and a sense of alienation from God.
- **Eradicate Blessings:** They strip away the *barakah* (blessing) in one's time, wealth, and relationships.
- **Breed More Sins:** Ibn Qayyim eloquently explains how one sin invites another, creating a vicious cycle of addiction.

III. The Devastating Sickness of Unlawful Attachment (Al-'Ishq)

A massive portion of *Ad-Daa' wad-Dawaa'* is dedicated to a specific, debilitating disease of the heart: 'Ishq (obsessive, passionate infatuation or unlawful attachment to another human being). Ibn Qayyim diagnoses 'Ishq not as a romantic ideal—as poetry often portrays it—but as a severe spiritual malignancy that enslaves the soul.

He explains that the heart is created to love and be devoted to its Creator. When a heart is emptied of the genuine love of Allah, it creates a vacuum. This empty, weakened heart desperately latches onto the creation, leading to an obsessive attachment that eventually turns into a form of psychological and spiritual slavery ('ubudiyyah to other than Allah).

Summarizing the tragic reality of this attachment, Ibn Qayyim lays down a profound spiritual axiom³:

من أحب شيئاً غير الله عذب به

“Whoever loves something other than Allah will inevitably be tormented by it.”

— Ibn Qayyim al-Jawziyyah, *Ad-Dā' wad-Dawā'*

Ibn Qayyim outlines the profound dangers of 'Ishq:

- It occupies the mind entirely, leaving no room for the remembrance of God.
- It corrupts one's priorities, causing a person to sacrifice their faith, wealth, and dignity for the sake of the beloved.

The ultimate cure for ‘Ishq, he argues, cannot be found in indulging it, but in severing the attachment and forcefully redirecting the heart’s immense capacity for love back toward its rightful owner: Allah. True monotheism (Tawheed) is the only antidote powerful enough to break the chains of false, obsessive love.

IV. The Psychology of Temptation

Perhaps the most brilliant aspect of the book is Ibn Qayyim’s early formulation of what we might today call cognitive-behavioral psychology. He breaks down the anatomy of a sin into stages:

- Al-Khatarat (Passing Thoughts): The initial, involuntary thought.
- Al-Fikrat (Ideation/Reflection): Entertaining the thought and dwelling on it.
- Ash-Shahawat (Desires): The thought transforming into a craving.
- Al-’Aza’im (Firm Resolve): The conscious decision to act.
- Al-Afaal (Actions): The physical commission of the sin.

He advises the “patient” that the easiest point to cut off the disease is at the very first stage—repelling the passing thought before it takes root in the heart.

V. The Power of the Cure (Ad-Dawaa’)

Having thoroughly diagnosed the illness, Ibn Qayyim administers the cure. The remedy is multi-faceted, relying on a profound shift in perspective and proactive spiritual practices.

1. The Weapon and Shield of Duā’ (Supplication)

Ibn Qayyim champions Duā’ as the most potent medicine available to the believer. Emphasizing its power, he writes⁴:

والدعاء من أنفع الأدوية، وهو عدو البلاء، يدافعه ويعالجه

“Supplication is among the most beneficial of medicines. It is the enemy of affliction; it repels it and treats it.”

— Ibn Qayyim al-Jawziyyah, Ad-Dā’ wad-Dawā’

He masterfully answers a common philosophical dilemma: if everything is pre-decreed by God (Qadar), what is the point of making Duā’?

Ibn Qayyim argues that Duā’ itself is part of the Divine Decree. Just as a person uses a shield to repel an arrow, one uses Duā’ to repel a tribulation. He categorizes the dynamic between Duā’

and a looming calamity into three scenarios:

- The Duā' is stronger than the calamity: it entirely repels the affliction before it even strikes.
- The Duā' is weaker than the calamity: the affliction strikes, but the Duā' softens its blow and makes it bearable.
- They are of equal strength: they wrestle with one another, preventing the affliction from fully overwhelming the believer.

2. The Majesty of Tawheed (Monotheism)

The root of all spiritual diseases, according to Ibn Qayyim, is a deficiency in one's understanding of Allah. The cure lies in elevating one's knowledge of God's Names and Attributes. When the heart is filled with the awe, love, and reverence of the Creator, the allure of the creation diminishes. You cannot rid the heart of a false love without replacing it with a greater, truer love.

3. Sincere Repentance (Tawbah)

The door to healing is never closed. Ibn Qayyim details the conditions of sincere repentance—remorse, immediate cessation of the sin, and a firm resolve never to return to it. He emphasizes God's infinite mercy and His joy when a servant returns to Him.

4. Guarding the “Gates” of the Heart

The author provides practical advice on guarding the entry points to the heart: the eyes, the ears, the tongue, and the stomach. It is deeply reminiscent of what modern writers often say⁵: “you are what you consume.” Ibn Qayyim understood this centuries ago. This doesn't just apply to physical food, but to the information, media, and conversations we ingest. By strictly controlling what one looks at, listens to, and consumes, a person protects their internal spiritual ecosystem from toxic influences.

VI. Key Takeaways for the Modern Reader

- Sin is a Sickness, not just a Crime: Treating spiritual struggles as illnesses fosters a mindset of healing and recovery rather than mere guilt and despair.
- The Vacuum of the Heart: If you do not fill your heart with the love of the Divine, it will inevitably become enslaved to the love of the creation, leading to ruinous attachments (Ishq).
- Nip it in the Bud: Guard your thoughts. The battle is lost or won in the mind before the limbs ever move.

- Duā' is Proactive, Not Passive: Supplication is an active, dynamic force that physically wrestles with tribulations in the unseen realm.
- Never Despair: No matter how deep the spiritual abyss, the medicine of Tawbah and Duā' is always stronger than the disease.

VII. A Final Word

Closing my journal for now, I realize that Ad-Daa' wad-Dawaa' is not light reading; it is a profound, surgical examination of the human soul. Imam Ibn Qayyim writes with the precision of a scholar, the wisdom of a psychologist, and the profound empathy of a spiritual guide.

For anyone struggling with destructive habits, spiritual emptiness, or simply seeking a deeper connection with their Creator, this book is a timeless prescription. It proves that while human struggles remain the same across centuries, the Divine cure is eternally effective.

Notes

1. Ibn Qayyim al-Jawziyyah, *Ad-Dā' wad-Dawā'* ("The Disease and The Cure"), opening thesis, citing the Prophetic principle that Allah sends down no disease without also sending down its cure.
2. *Ad-Dā' wad-Dawā'*, on sin as poison to the heart.
3. *Ad-Dā' wad-Dawā'*, on the torment of loving other than Allah.
4. *Ad-Dā' wad-Dawā'*, on supplication as medicine against affliction and its role within the Divine Decree.
5. Attributed broadly across contemporary self-improvement writing; echoed by writer Mark Manson.

About the Author

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Sibiyan Updulrauf is a writer and researcher on Islamic spirituality and philosophy. He writes on Substack, engaging classical Islamic scholarship alongside cross-disciplinary literary and philosophical works.